



Arjun Singh

AFP PHOTO/PRAKASH SINGH

a slightly worse scenario."

ARJUN SINGH, HRD MINISTER

lifetime of loyalty to the Family.

Most Congressmen still recall the late Sitaram Kesri's warning about the canny Thakur, "This man is so shrewd that if you put a nail in his head, it will come out as a screw." In fact, Singh's recent comments distancing himself from the Emergency are also being seen as an attempt to woo the Left. Dismissing his contention that he had voiced his criticism of the

ROYAL REBUFF: Singh's latest attempt at flattery has miffed Sonia



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Emergency to both Indira Gandhi and her son Sanjay, as "a colourful lie", Parliamentary Affairs Minister Vayalar Ravi said, "I don't know what his gameplan is. Maybe he is trying to boost his image and get friendly with the Left." After all, say Congressmen, in a possible post-Manmohan and a pre-Rahul scenario, the communists could come in useful.

Despite protests to the contrary, it is not that the current leadership is averse to flattery. It merely prefers Powerpoint presentations of sycophancy to the old style sloganeering and prostrating. Unfortunately, Singh has not kept in tune with the changing times. The old school of durbar politics is outdated in the powerplay of Rahul Gandhi's new age Congress. According to a Congress leader from Madhya Pradesh, before Singh began his Rahul-for-PM chant, he met the young heir apparent at a social function and asked for time to call on him. The young Gandhi replied he would call on the older leader instead. The problem is: Rahul never did.

So far, Singh's political instincts have mostly been on the right side—whether it was his response to the Babri Masjid demolition in 1992, his criticism of the tardy implementation of the Jain Commission report in 1994 or the recent reservations policy—but each time he fails to ride the wave. Instead of resigning in the aftermath of Babri demolition, he chose to wait till 1994 to quit Rao's cabinet under the pretext of the Jain Commission report. The mosque would have been a leader's gamble. The Jain Commission report was a courtier's fawn.

Now he is getting a bit desperate. Walking stick in hand, the septuagenarian knows all too well that this is his last stab at relevancy. His retirement plan is not the manicured lawn of a Raj Bhavan. He scotched an attempt at being sidelined as Maharashtra governor two months ago by taking on Raj Thackeray which ensured that he was no longer an objective observer of the state's politics. Clearly, Singh has lost none of the craft and cunning that Kesri had credited him with. He is now working on his autobiography. Those who know him well also know that the last chapter is yet to be written. He still has some unfinished business. ■